

SOCIAL MEDIA: ITS INFLUENCE ON THE COMPREHENSION SKILLS OF STUDENTS

MIRALUNA T. SABID, EdD

*Capiz State University, Roxas City Main Campus
Roxas City, Capiz, Philippines*

Despite the vast research conducted on the use of social media, little is known about the influence social media could make on the reading comprehension level of learners thus, this quantitative research was conducted. This study is anchored on connectivism it suggests students should combine thoughts, theories, and general information usefully. It accepts that technology is a major part of the learning process. It promotes collaboration, discussion, and learning outside of an individual, such as through social media, online networks, blogs, or information databases (Siemens & Downes, 2004). It aimed to determine the influence of social media on learners' reading comprehension skills. The respondents are the 309 randomly selected first-year students of CapSU Roxas City Main Campus S.Y. 2022-2023. Data were gathered using researcher-made questionnaire. Using the SPSS, data were coded and analyzed. It was found that the level of influence of social media on the reading comprehension skills of respondents is high, while the reading comprehension level is proficient. Furthermore, a significant relationship was found between the level of influence of social media and the level of reading comprehension skills of the learners. These imply that social media positively influence the development of the learners' reading comprehension skills. It has evolved to be a learning resource for reading materials. This means that the more the learners read using social media, the better the chances of enhancing their reading comprehension skills.

Keywords: social media, reading comprehension, influence, qualitative research

Introduction and Objectives

Most classroom activities and tasks need to be read and understood. Reading is one of the macro-skills that a learner should master to become communicatively proficient. It is making meaning to the written symbols and letters. Reading includes several skills that a learner should develop from basic education and beyond. These are decoding, phonemic awareness, reading fluency, and reading comprehension. Thus, a learner in an online class must have developed a higher level of reading comprehension skills to understand the tasks.

Reading comprehension, on the other hand, refers to an ability to acquire literal or inferential meaning from the given text through the interaction between sentences' cognition process and situation image construction (Dong et al.,2021). It is considered the most complex process in reading, for it requires the reader to figure out what the print represents. In higher education reading is mostly required for self-development and better comprehension. However, the COVID-19 pandemic has brought changes in the lives of Filipinos and people around the globe, so as the reading practice. The internet and internet-based platforms have kept people at home and in the workplace anywhere in the world connected. Furthermore, reading has also shifted from printed materials to online platforms. In

the Philippines, social media is the most common platform used by teachers and students in facilitating teaching and learning (Baria, 2021). Social media has been found to be an effective way to stay connected to people around us. To students, social media is the most convenient way to use in communicate and share or acquire information (Sharna, 2019). It allowed students to work on their assignments, read to gain information, do self-study, and discuss topics while being connected on social media. Will it also serve as a better platform that could influence a better level of reading comprehension for learners?

This study sought to determine the influence of social media on the reading comprehension skills of learners. Specifically, it answered the following questions; 1) What is the level of influence of social media on the reading comprehension skills of the respondents? 2) What is the level of reading comprehension skills of the respondents? and 3) Is there a significant relationship between the influence of social media and the level of reading skills of the respondents? This study is anchored on the connectivism learning theory of Siemens and Downes (2004). This theory posits that connectivism is a learning theory when learners put theories, thoughts, and other information to use. It also believes that technology is a significant part of this learning process and that continual connection gives learners a chance to learn. It further discussed that connectivism is a learning theory for the digital age (Siemens, 2012).

Materials and Methods or Methodology

Research Design

This study utilized the descriptive-correlational research design, descriptive research is research designed to provide a snapshot of the current state of affairs. Correlational research is research designed to discover relationships among variables and to allow the prediction of future events from present knowledge (Tankersley, 2015). This design describes a situation or a given state of affairs in terms of specified aspects or factors. What may be described are characteristics of individuals or groups, physical environments, or conditions. In this study, the phenomenon being described is the role of social media in developing the reading comprehension skills of learners. The statistical tools used are mean, frequency, standard deviation, and T-test for inferential statistics.

Respondents

The participants of the study were the 309 randomly selected first year students of Capiz State University enrolled in the first semester of the school year 2022-2023 . The sample size of the participants were calculated through the use of Raosoft Calculator (<http://www.raosoft.com/samplesize.html>). To determine the sample size per college, a stratified random sampling was utilized.

Instruments

Data were gathered through the use of a researcher-made questionnaire which was sent through a Google form. It is a 3-part questionnaire. Part I is for the personal information of the respondents for profiling. Part II is on the roles of social

media in developing the comprehension skills of learners. Part III is to measure the comprehension skills of the learners. The instrument was piloted to 30 first-year students of CapSU Roxas who were not included in the survey. The validity and reliability of the instrument were tested using Cronbach's alpha. The result showed a reliability coefficient score of 0.836 which indicated that the instrument is valid.

To interpret and analyze the level of comprehension of respondents the following scale was used.

Scale	Verbal Interpretation
23.24 – 30	Advanced
17.43 – 23.23	Proficient
11.62 – 17.42	Developing
5.81 – 11.61	Emerging
0.00 – 5.80	Beginning

To interpret the level of influence of social media on reading comprehension the following scale was utilized.

Scale	Response Category	Verbal Interpretation
4.24 – 5.00	Strongly Agree	Very High
3.43 – 4.23	Agree	High
2.63 – 3.42	Neutral	Moderately high
1.81 – 2.61	Disagree	Low
1.0 – 1.8	Strongly Disagree	Very low

Results and Discussions

Level of influence of social media

The level of influence of social media in developing the reading skills of the respondents is high as reflected in the mean of 3.94. Specifically, the statement which says "Social media helps me understand what I am reading easily," is Very High with a mean score of 4.7 while the statement which says "Social media helps me draw conclusions from the text I've read," is very low with the mean score of 1.5. This means that social media poses a significant contribution to the development of the reading skills of students. This could be attributed to the fact that students spend an ample amount of time daily checking and engaging in their social media accounts enabling them to sharpen their comprehension through text

and pictures content shown in their accounts. Likewise, in order for students to stay connected and interact on social media, they need to continually keep themselves well-informed and updated by gathering information and facts which highly improves their personal reading comprehension. Furthermore, it could also mean that though social media helps the learners to understand facts, the influence on the development of comprehension using the higher-order thinking skills based on Bloom's Revised Taxonomy (Armstrong 2010) is low which implies that social media contents did not trigger the use of higher order thinking skills. The results of this study confirm the study of Hussain, M., Kubravi, U., & Amad, F. (2021) which found that the majority of the students also agree or strongly agree that social networking sites help in improving reading skills, understanding text, and developing book reading, newspaper reading, and critical reading. However, studies of Liu, Hu & Bi (2023), found that social media use tends to have a more significant impact on leisure reading than on academic reading.

Table 1. Level of influence of social media

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Verbal Interpretation
Social media	309	3.94	.209	High

Legend: 1.00 – 1.80 - Very Low, 1.81 – 2.61 – Low, 2.62 – 3.42 - Moderately High, 3.43 – 4.23 - High, 4.24 – 5.00 - Very High

Level of Comprehension Skills of Respondents

The level of reading comprehension skills of the respondents is proficient as reflected in the mean of 3.84. This signifies that the students already possess the capability to express understanding of the text read. It also means that students are almost independently able to read through a text and understand its context and implications. Most likely, students under this level have mastered the basic rudimentary skills for reading and had eventually been able to be familiar with the language used and understand the printed text. Generally, this contends that students can be given reading materials and can capably comprehend and discuss the material. Results of this study affirmed the findings of Bilbao, Dongiula & Vasay (2016) which found that the overall reading comprehension of the Education students is Satisfactory with a descriptive level of Moderate, additionally, the findings of Qholbi & Fitrawati (2022) found that students' level on reading comprehension was categorized into an average level.

Table 2. Level of reading comprehension

Variable	N	Mean	SD	Verbal Interpretation
Reading comprehension	309	3.84	.240	Proficient

Legend: 1.00 – 1.80 – Beginning, 1.81 – 2.61 – Developing, 2.62 – 3.42 - Approaching proficiency, 3.43 – 4.23 - Proficient, 4.24 – 5.00- Advanced

Relationship between Social Media and Reading Comprehension

There is a significant relationship between the influence of social media and the level of reading comprehension skills ($r = .749$, $p = .000$) of the students. This reflects that the student's active engagement with social media platforms is inadvertently connected to their reading comprehension level and vice versa. This reflects that the amount of time spent by the students on their social media accounts has positively improved their reading comprehension skills. This may point out the fact that social media contains content, advertisements, conversations, and other forms of text that invite and compels users to read in order to respond to their accounts. Specifically, as a process, social media accounts encourage users to interact, and in order to successfully convey an interaction, a significant understanding is required, and this can only be materialized by gaining a higher level of reading comprehension. Thus, social media directly contributes to the reading comprehension of the students. The results of this study confirmed the findings of Kojo, Agyekum, Arthur (2018), which found that the use of social media by students has a statistically significant impact on the reading culture and to an extent their academic performance. Moreover, findings of Mukhallafi (2020) found that using social media as an ELT tool in their classrooms improves reading skills. The findings also indicate that social networking websites and applications (e.g. Facebook, Youtube, Twitter, Skype) have a positive impact on reading comprehension.

Table 3. Relationship between social media and reading comprehension

Variable	N	Pearson R Correlation	Sig. (2tailed)	Remarks
Social media	309	.749**	.000	Significant

**Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed)

Conclusions and Recommendations

Conclusions

Based on the findings of this study, the following conclusions were drawn;

1. Social media positively influenced the development of the reading comprehension skills of the respondents. This implies that in terms of improving the ability to comprehend the students, their social media engagements have helped them improve their skills and exposure to texts and other content. Evidently, social media paved a generally accessible source for reading materials and content for students may it be in academic pursuit or purely out of personal interest.
2. The reading comprehension of the students is well-established and just one notch short of attaining highly proficient, the highest. This implies that students had already acquired basic skills and strategies, improved word vocabulary and fluency as well as established reader-text relationships.
3. Social media influences the development of reading comprehension skills. This asserts that social media has become an active learning material resource for students in improving their reading comprehension. Since it is highly accessible and indicative of students' high engagement, social media served as a venue for harnessing the reading comprehension of students.

Recommendations

Based on the findings and conclusions of this study the following are the recommendations;

1. Teachers may be encouraged to continuously use social media as a source of learning materials/content for students to practice their reading comprehension since it has a high influence on reading comprehension. Moreover, provide or use content that may provoke the use of higher-order thinking skills to help improve the higher-order thinking skills of the learners.
2. A reading material may be authored or compiled by the Instructors / Professors as additional learning material to continually encourage students to improve their reading comprehension and may upload them using the social media platform. To reach the maximum reading level, teachers may consider giving tasks not only by using social media but also materials from books and other academic online platforms to maximize the reading engagement of students. They may utilize the Interactive reading comprehension practice set which they can access through the social media platform.
3. Since social media has become a vital component of the daily life of tertiary students, and was found to have an influence on the reading comprehension of students, teachers, and students may use social media prudently. It may be used reasonably as a vital information source and for conducting academic activities.